

TAKING FLIGHT AT CAROLINA RAPTOR CENTER

It's a common sight at Charlotte's Carolina Raptor Center: Young children stand awestruck in front of cages watching eagles, owls, vultures, falcons and other birds of prey, many of them alive only because of nurturing by Raptor Center staff and volunteers.

Raptors are so cool and interesting and it's really fun to learn about them," said Emily Rietz, a fifth grade teacher at Trinity Episcopal School in Charlotte who took her students to visit the center.

"We got to see one of the eagle mothers sitting on her nest," said Rietz. "Our guide cautioned us to be silent so we wouldn't disturb the mother and our 45 students were mesmerized."

Located on a 57-acre site north of Charlotte in the Latta Nature Preserve, the Carolina Raptor Center (CRC) is a living museum and rehabilitation educational facility with about 100 birds as permanent residents due to incapacitation or inability to feed themselves, and another 800 a year rehabilitated and released to the wild.

Some birds are trained to participate in educational programs and occasionally brought out by keepers for closer looks.

"We are a refuge for birds of prey, and we use the raptors to teach people about the environment," said Jim Warren, CRC interim CEO. About 40,000 people visit annually to see and learn more about the raptors, some of whom have found permanent homes at the CRC.

"You see bald eagles, golden eagles, various species of owls, hawks, vultures, and falcons on our display trail," said Warren, although not all of the birds on display are native to this area.

Visitors get a good view of the birds in cages along the trail and these raptors are a bit acclimated to people, said Warren.



Photo courtesy of Carolina Raptor Center

"We caution people... raptors are meat eaters, so you don't want to stick a finger up there or they may perceive that you're trying to give them food," said Warren.

Volunteers

A "spiritual" place is how volunteer docent Cecil Givens from Rock Hill, S.C., describes the CRC.

"You feel very calm and close to nature when you're here," said Givens, a retired 40-year educator and amateur ornithologist, who teaches weekend programs at the CRC. "Our mission really is conservation and we use the birds to help explain it."

Birds often become injured in the wild looking for food or dodging vehicles. Injured birds may be unable to hunt to feed themselves and get progressively weaker.

The CRC takes them in and nurses them back to health while being careful not to imprint them to become too

dependent on humans, said Warren. A full-time veterinarian and 25-person staff, along with 300 volunteers, work to provide medical treatment, physical therapy and feeding for the birds. The CRC has flight cages larger than 100 feet in length, a necessary accommodation for exercising and conditioning an injured raptor prior to its release, explained Warren.

Wild Release

"We have the highest release rate of any bird center in the U.S.," said Warren. "We receive more than 700 birds each year and treat them for free. We don't keep any birds here unless they are physically or emotionally unable to live outside."

Birds come to the CRC from policemen and conservation officers and from veterinarians and animal control officers, said Warren.

"People often call and ask for someone to come rescue a bird and we send volunteers to bring the injured bird back to the CRC for treatment," said Warren.

This year, the CRC rescued a bald eagle from Georgia that had been shot, rehabilitated and released it, said Warren.

Among the five bald eagles who live permanently at the CRC are Savannah and Derek, said Warren, who have given birth to three babies in the past three years, all released when they reached about 12 weeks of age and had sufficient flight and hunting skills to become self-sufficient.



Education at the Carolina Raptor Center: Kids learn responsibility to share their knowledge with the community in hopes that their career enthusiasm will spread.

To supplement its \$1.5 million budget, most generated from admission fees (\$5-\$7 per person, under 5 free) and grants, and used to treat and rehab raptors, the CRC depends on its 300 volunteers.

Many volunteers, such as Givens, offer regular weekend programs, included in the CRC's regular admission price, or outreach programs for preschoolers to adults. Special winter programs include Owl/Pow! in December and Wild Wings Winter Festival in January.

Collisions

"Almost 40 percent of all our injured birds come to the Center after car collisions," said Givens. "The bones of birds are hollow to help them fly and they shatter like glass when they are hit by cars."

People contribute to the collisions, said Givens, when they throw litter or even biodegradable things like apple cores out of the car onto roadways. The wide-open spaces, mowed on the sides to increase visibility, also make the roads attractive to prey. Raptors watch and when they see prey such as rats or mice scampers toward litter, they zoom in on the hunt, paying no attention to the cars.

"In just a short time at the Center people can learn so much about birds and how to protect them," said Givens. "I've been volunteering there for two years and each time I go, I learn something new."

"It's a great place to visit and I'm lucky to be there," said Givens.

The CRC is open to the public almost year-round (closed on Thanksgiving, Christmas, New Year's Day and Easter). Consider a visit to the CRC and then picnic, hike, or go horseback riding at the Latta Nature Preserve, or tour the Historic Latta Plantation and living history farm. — Carol Gifford

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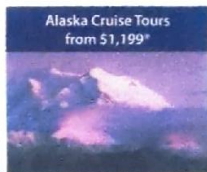
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